

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Hosea 1:1

The Lord gave this message: The book of Hosea begins by declaring that these are not merely human words but a message from the only true God (cp. [Joel 1:1](#); [Mic 1:1](#); [Zeph 1:1](#)). • Hosea son of Beeri: Several other important people in the Old Testament are also named Hosea (or Hoshea; both are spelled the same in Hebrew; [Num 13:8](#); [2 Kgs 17:1](#)). Hosea means “the Lord saves,” an appropriate name for this prophet. • Jeroboam . . . king of Israel: Hosea prophesied to the northern kingdom of Israel during the reigns of its last seven kings, though only one of them, Jeroboam II, is listed here (see Hosea Book Introduction, “Setting”).

Hosea 1:2–3

a prostitute: Some have found it impossible to believe that God would command a prophet to marry a prostitute. As a result, there is a long tradition of interpreting this passage symbolically. Many in the early church believed that the marriage did not actually take place. They thought that this passage was an allegory in which Hosea represented the Lord and Gomer represented Israel. Today, most interpreters regard the marriage as a real one, but they differ in their ideas about Gomer’s occupation prior to the marriage. Some suggest that Gomer was an ordinary prostitute, while others suggest that she was one of the sacred prostitutes involved in Canaanite fertility worship. Another possibility is that Gomer was a young woman who had not previously participated in illicit sexual activity, but whom God knew to be predisposed toward adultery and prostitution.

Hosea 1:2–3.5

This section describes a small segment of the prophet’s life, focusing on his unhappy marriage and illuminating God’s painful relationship with Israel, his chosen people.

Hosea 1:4

Jezreel is a fertile valley in north central Israel. • The murders Jehu committed at Jezreel are described in [2 Kgs 9–10](#).

Hosea 1:5

King Tiglath-pileser III of Assyria fulfilled this prophecy in 733 BC when he defeated Israelite forces and captured the Valley of Jezreel.

Hosea 1:6

Lo-ruhamah: The names of Hosea’s children were part of his prophetic message (cp. [Isa 7:10–8:8](#)).

Hosea 1:7

For many years, the kingdom of Israel had depended upon its armies and horses and charioteers for security, but its confidence was completely misplaced. Safety and security are only to be found in God’s power as the Lord.

Hosea 1:9

The name Lo-ammi carries the harshest judgment of all, because it seems to announce the end of Israel’s covenant relationship with the Lord. The cherished title my people—bestowed upon Israel when they lived obediently in covenant with the Lord their God ([Lev 26:12](#); see also [Exod 6:7](#))—was now withdrawn due to their blatant unfaithfulness. • I am not their God: The Hebrew behind this declaration can be translated *I am not ‘I Am’ for you* (cp. [Exod 3:14](#)). The third child’s name prophetically announces that the Israelites stand outside the covenant and are no longer privileged to call upon the I Am.

Hosea 1:10

sands of the seashore: This promise of future population growth for God’s people echoes the

promise given to the patriarchs Abraham and Jacob ([Gen 22:17](#); [32:12](#)). • You are children of the living God: This expression is found nowhere else in the Old Testament, but Paul quoted this verse ([Rom 9:26](#)) to establish that God had also called the Gentiles to salvation.

Hosea 1:10–11

These verses mark an abrupt shift in Hosea's prophecy from judgment to hope. In the next three verses, Hosea transforms the names of Gomer's three children from names of divine punishment on Israel into names of blessing and hope. This dramatically demonstrates God's sovereign power of reversal from darkness to light, judgment to hope, and even death to life.

Hosea 1:11

Judah and Israel will unite together: For almost 200 years, Israel and Judah had been divided into separate kingdoms by political rivalry. When God restores his people, he will reunite the divided kingdoms under a single leader as in the time of David, and he will reverse the curse of exile (see also [Ezek 37:15–28](#)). • The day of Jezreel: Hosea announced that in a coming time, God would restore the original meaning of Jezreel. It would signify blessing and growth rather than judgment.

Hosea 2:1

Ammi—'My people': God will also restore the name of the third child to its covenantal meaning. • Ruhamah—"The ones I love": Israel will once again be the object of God's love and compassion.

Hosea 2:2–23

bring charges against Israel: At first glance, the Lord, as the aggrieved husband, appears to be issuing a bill of divorce against his unfaithful spouse, Israel (see [Deut 24:1](#)). As the passage continues, however, it becomes clear that God's purpose in this lawsuit is not divorce, but reconciliation ([Hos 2:14–23](#)). God's case against Israel is intended to awaken Israel to her sin and offer her a chance to return to her true husband. The Lord's desire for reconciliation with Israel is all

the more surprising inasmuch as the law stipulated the death penalty for an adulterous spouse ([Deut 22:22](#); see also [Gen 38:24](#); [Lev 21:9](#)).

Hosea 2:3

The Lord warns unfaithful Israel that unless she repents and returns to her covenant partner, he will strip her . . . naked (see also [2:10](#)). Ezekiel also employs this image of judgment and shame ([Ezek 16:36–37](#)).

Hosea 2:5

The only evidence needed to prove Israel's unfaithfulness comes from her own words: I'll run after other lovers. Israel's lovers were the Canaanite fertility deities, especially the baals (local representations of Baal). The Israelites worshiped them because they believed that these gods controlled the reproductive forces in nature. The Israelites attributed to them the basic necessities of life, food and water, their clothing of wool and linen, and oil, used for both sacred and secular purposes.

Hosea 2:6–7

For this reason (literally *Therefore*): The initial Hebrew word of [2:6](#) (also of [2:9](#) and [2:14](#)) introduces God's judgment on Israel. Because of her idolatry, the Lord would restrict Israel's access to the Canaanite fertility gods. Like an aggressive prostitute, she will pursue her lovers; but she will not find them. In the end, Israel will conclude that it is better to return to her rightful husband.

Hosea 2:8

She doesn't realize (literally *she doesn't know*): Israel needs to know God personally and experientially. Had the Israelites known the Lord in this way, they would have realized that every good thing in their lives came from him, not from the baals.

Hosea 2:9–13

God's first judgment ([2:6–7](#)) was to restrict the Israelites; this second judgment would be to remove and destroy what he alone had given them.

Hosea 2:11

From the context ([2:13](#), [16–17](#)), as well as from similar passages in [Isa 1:12–17](#) and [Amos 5:21–24](#), it seems clear that the Israelites had defiled the legitimate festivals, new moon celebrations, and Sabbath days by combining worship of the Lord with worship of the Canaanite fertility god, Baal. God rejects such *syncretism* (mixing of different faiths) and declared that he would remove these unholy days from Israel's calendar.

Hosea 2:13

While the Israelites were worshiping Canaanite gods, they forgot the Lord. For Hosea, *to forget* is not a lapse of memory, but the opposite of *knowing* the Lord (see [8:14](#); [13:6](#); [Job 8:12–13](#)). Had Israel truly known the Lord, they would never have indulged in Baal worship.

Hosea 2:14–15

The third judgment (see note on [2:6–7](#)) is completely unexpected. The Lord, who had innocently suffered Israel's repeated unfaithfulness, announces that he will take the initiative in wooing Israel in order to win her back once again. He will lead her into the desert where he first entered into covenant with her, away from the seductive influences of Canaanite religion. • The Valley of Trouble was the scene of Israel's first act of disobedience after they entered the Promised Land ([Josh 7:24–26](#)). The Lord had both the will and the power to grant Israel a new beginning after their sin and trouble ([Josh 8:1–22](#)), so Israel would again be offered a gateway of hope.

Hosea 2:16

that day: This seemingly unremarkable phrase is actually quite important in the prophets. It refers to the coming day of the Lord (see [Joel 1:15](#); [2:1](#); [Amos 5:18](#)), when the Lord will act decisively in

human history on behalf of his people. • 'my husband' instead of 'my master': In this coming day, Israel will enter into a new relationship with her God. No longer will Israel call God "master" (Hebrew *ba'al*), which connotes subservience and was also the name of the chief Canaanite fertility god. Instead, she will address the Lord as "husband," implying partnership and companionship ([Gen 2:23–24](#)).

Hosea 2:17

To avoid any possible syncretism between the Lord and Baal, God would wipe the many names of Baal from Israel's lips.

Hosea 2:18

On that day the Lord would make a covenant with his creation and his people, a covenant of peace and safety.

Hosea 2:19–20

I will make you my wife: This Hebrew verb, used three times in these verses, can be translated with our seldom-used word *betroth*. In the ancient world, betrothal entailed all the legal steps of a marriage, including the payment of a bride price by the groom. The only thing missing was the marriage ceremony and sexual consummation. The Lord vowed to betroth Israel to himself forever. To ensure the eternal nature of this new marriage, God provided a bride price that included five priceless qualities: righteousness and justice, unfailing love and compassion, and faithfulness. As a result, the Lord said, Israel will finally know me (cp. [2:13](#)).

Hosea 2:21–22

Unfaithful Israel thought her food and clothing were gifts from her lovers, the baals ([2:5](#)), but in that day they will know that the Lord alone is the source of all fertility and blessing. He will answer the sky, the clouds, and the earth, initiating the true cycle of fertility for the land. When the Lord is recognized as the only source of life, then the name Jezreel will regain its true meaning: God plants!

Hosea 2:23

As God has promised ([2:1](#)), on the coming day of the Lord he will reverse the names of Gomer's children. He will show love to 'Not loved.' To 'Not my people,' he will say, 'Now you are my people.' The only fitting response from God's people is "You are our God!"

Hosea 3:1

Go and love your wife again, even though she: The Lord commanded Hosea to restore his marriage as testimony that the Lord had promised to restore wayward Israel. • love to worship them: Literally *love their raisin cakes*. The worship of Asherah, a Canaanite fertility goddess, often included offerings of raisin cakes.

Hosea 3:2

So I bought her back: The biblical text does not indicate why the prophet needed to purchase his wife. Most interpreters have assumed that the unfaithful Gomer had fallen into debt and become a slave. The meager price Hosea paid for her may indicate that Gomer was considered a slave of little value (see [Exod 21:32](#); [Lev 27:4](#)).

Hosea 3:3-4

Just as Hosea's wife was required to live many days without sexual relations, Israel would be deprived of the institutions (king or prince), practices (sacrifices), and objects (sacred pillars . . . or even idols) that had been foundational to its life and worship.

Hosea 3:5

The Lord's purpose for depriving the Israelites of these things was to get them to return to him in reverential awe and recognize him alone as the source of all goodness.

Hosea 4:1

The Lord has brought charges against you: Hosea issued a divine indictment against Israel for

breaking their covenant with the Lord (see also [Isa 3:13](#); [Mic 6:2](#)). The charges first focus on sins of omission, the qualities that should characterize the people of Israel but were absent. In Israel there is no faithfulness, no kindness, no knowledge of God. These theologically rich words describe the inward trust and devotion from which godly lives should spring.

Hosea 4:1-14.9

This diverse collection of Hosea's prophecies is presented in roughly chronological order, from early in his ministry during the reign of Jeroboam II until just before the destruction of Israel in 722 BC. Hosea presents God's charges against Israel, tells them of the severe consequences for their sin, and concludes with a divine promise of future restoration.

Hosea 4:2

The prophet also charged the Israelites for their sins of commission. The crimes listed here are all prohibited in the Ten Commandments ([Exod 20:3-17](#); [Deut 5:7-21](#)), the fundamental list of covenant responsibilities. Because the Israelites did not know the Lord, they did not practice even the most basic standards of covenant life.

Hosea 4:3

God's judgment inevitably falls upon sinful people. Because of the Israelites' sin, their land and all of nature would suffer.

Hosea 4:4-5

When we are accused of a crime, our human inclination is to blame someone else, but God makes it clear that the blame for Israel's apostasy lay with her religious leaders, priests, and false prophets. • God's judgment on the priests and prophets was that they would stumble and fall (the same word in Hebrew), both professionally and personally.

Hosea 4:6

Because the priests refused to know the Lord, neither did the people know their God. As a result, the people were being destroyed. • A primary function of the priests of Israel was to know, practice, and teach the laws of . . . God. Ironically, these guardians of the law had forgotten it.

Hosea 4:9

The people followed the evil example of their religious leaders; as a result, God would punish both priests and people for their wicked deeds.

Hosea 4:10

God's judgment matches the punishment to the crime. The Israelites worshiped Canaanite fertility deities with the expectation of bountiful crops and herds, but God's judgment was that they would still be hungry and their religious prostitution would gain them nothing.

Hosea 4:12

They ask a piece of wood for advice! For millennia, people have worshiped natural objects such as wood and stones that they believed embodied spirits and gods ([Jer 2:27](#)). Biblical religion completely rejects such practices and beliefs ([Exod 20:4-5](#); [Isa 44:19](#)).

Hosea 4:13

Many Canaanite religious rites were practiced on the mountaintops and hills. On these pagan "high places," sacred trees were usually used in fertility worship ([1 Kgs 14:23](#); [Jer 2:20](#)). • Israelite daughters and brides also committed sexual acts in the worship of Baal; they were possibly forced to do so by their fathers and husbands.

Hosea 4:14

God declared that he would not single out the young women for their prostitution. This declaration contrasts with double standards that were common in ancient cultures. • shrine

prostitutes: The Hebrew word refers to female prostitutes who were dedicated to the service of Baal and Asherah in the temples of Baal ([Deut 23:18](#)).

Hosea 4:15

Beth-aven refers to the wickedness being practiced at Bethel, the most important worship center in the northern kingdom of Israel (see [Amos 7:13](#); cp. [Hos 5:8](#); [10:5](#)).

Hosea 5:1

Hosea again condemns the religious and political leaders of Israel. They have led the people into idolatry as hunters trap wild animals in a snare. • The specific sins at Mizpah and Tabor are not known.

Hosea 5:2

I will settle with you: God's judgment (Hebrew *musar*, "discipline") would inevitably fall upon Israel's leaders. God did not judge Israel simply to punish them, but to correct them so that his people would return to him.

Hosea 5:3

you are utterly defiled: The word translated *defiled* is used frequently in the Pentateuch to describe ritual uncleanness, a physical condition that disqualified a person from worshiping God in the Temple ([Lev 11-15](#)). The prophets used the concept as a metaphor for Israel's moral uncleanness as the result of her idolatry ([Isa 6:5](#); [Mic 2:10](#)).

Hosea 5:4

Israel's idolatrous practices were so ingrained that they were apparently powerless to return to the Lord. • You are a prostitute through and through (literally *the spirit of prostitution is within them*): Israel's sin was not simply a behavior; it was the nation's essential nature. They instinctively preferred the corrupt to the pure. Only through God's work of salvation could Israel escape.

Hosea 5:6-7

The people might think that they could win God's favor with their sacrifices, but Hosea warned them that they would not find him; God had left them to the consequences of their sin.

Hosea 5:8-9

Hosea sounded the alarm to warn the Israelites of God's coming judgment. Because of their sins, the Lord had become Israel's enemy and would punish them. • Gibeah, Ramah, and Beth-aven (Bethel) are all cities in the tribal territory of Benjamin.

Hosea 5:10

thieves (literally *those who move a boundary marker*): The Lord was the owner of the land, which he entrusted to the tribes following the conquest (see [Josh 13:8-19:51](#)). To move a boundary marker and change God's allotted boundaries was to steal from God ([Deut 19:14](#)). Such an act rightly invoked divine punishment ([Deut 27:17](#)).

Hosea 5:12

as a moth . . . rotten wood: Sin can destroy the very fabric and foundation of a people while leaving them unaware that the destruction has taken place.

Hosea 5:13

In a final effort to avoid complete destruction, the Israelites overthrew King Pekah and placed a new king, Hoshea, on the throne. Hoshea then appealed to the Assyrian king Shalmaneser for peace ([2 Kgs 15:29-30](#); [17:3](#)), but these diplomatic maneuvers could neither help nor cure Israel—they would soon be destroyed by Assyria.

Hosea 5:15

Hosea again reminded Israel that divine judgment was not merely punitive. God's purpose was to

convince Israel to admit their guilt and return to the Lord (see [2:2](#), [14](#)).

Hosea 6:1-3

In response to God's acts of judgment on Israel, the religious leaders called the people to return to the Lord in repentance and urged everyone to know the Lord. • The rains in early spring were essential to the agricultural cycle of the land.

Hosea 6:4

The response of Israel was inadequate; God lamented that their love disappeared like morning mist and dew.

Hosea 6:6

In one of Hosea's key verses, God names the most important qualities that should characterize the Israelites' covenant lives with him. First, the Lord wants his people to show love more than he wants sacrifices. Love (Hebrew *khesed*) includes faithfulness (see [4:1](#); [6:4](#)). God is always faithful ([Ps 136](#)), and he requires the same of his people. Second, the Lord wants Israel to know him more than he wants burnt offerings. Knowing God is much more than simply knowing facts about God (see "Knowing God" Theme Note). An intimate personal relationship with God is characterized by complete trust and integrity. Sacrifice still had a proper place in Israelite religion, but only when it was offered by a people who truly knew and loved God (see [Isa 1:10-17](#); [Amos 5:21-24](#); [Mic 6:6-8](#)).

Hosea 6:7-11

Hosea traces the way that human rebellion against God began with Adam and spread through the cities of Israel to the land of Judah.

Hosea 6:9

Priests form bands of robbers: Hosea again condemns the religious leaders for their crimes (see [4:4-8](#)).

Hosea 6:10

something horrible: The prophet uses this rare word (also in [Jer 18:13](#)) to describe the depth of Israel's sin in breaking God's covenant and betraying his trust.

Hosea 7:1-2

I want to heal Israel: God's overwhelming desire was to heal Israel's harlotry (see [14:4](#)) and restore her to right relationship with him, but she was filled with liars, thieves, and bandits. • The Israelites might have thought that the Lord was unaware of their sins, but he was watching them, and he saw everything they did.

Hosea 7:3

The prophet did not record the name of this king, but many believe he was Hoshea, the northern kingdom's last monarch.

Hosea 7:3-7

The northern kingdom of Israel saw a succession of seven different kings during the final twenty-five years of its existence, four of whom were assassinated by usurpers. This passage refers to the vicious and bloody political intrigue that characterized these years.

Hosea 7:4

adulterers: Hosea used this term earlier to describe spiritual apostasy ([3:1](#)); it refers here to those who were disloyal to the king.

Hosea 7:6

A simile aptly compares the plots and political intrigue during this turbulent time to a red-hot oven that breaks out to ignite the entire land.

Hosea 7:7

They kill their kings: The people of Israel assassinated one king after another as they

desperately attempted to save their nation and their lives from the invading Assyrian army. Throughout these last years, they relied upon their own plans and plots and never thought to cry out to the Lord, their only true source of help.

Hosea 7:8

The people of Israel mingle with godless foreigners: By relying upon foreign nations rather than God for security, the Israelites were no longer a pure, holy nation, set apart for the Lord. • Flatbread must be turned over at the proper time to ensure that it is baked on both sides rather than burned on one side and raw on the other. Israel was a half-baked cake and was therefore worthless.

Hosea 7:8-12

Israel ignored the Lord in their international politics as well as in their domestic policies. Like silly, witless doves, they had flown in a frenzy between Assyria and Egypt, the major powers of their day, vainly trying to make treaties and alliances that would save their land.

Hosea 7:9

foreign gods (literally *foreigners*): Israel's political involvement with foreign nations had harmed their spiritual well-being.

Hosea 7:11

When invaded by Assyria, Israel turned to Egypt for help. When Egypt proved powerless, Israel tried to appease Assyria by becoming its *vassal* (a subservient kingdom).

Hosea 7:12

Like a fowler hunting birds, the Lord would throw his net over silly, witless Israel to punish them.

Hosea 7:13

What sorrow: This word (Hebrew 'oy) was used at funerals to mourn the dead. In God's eyes, Israel was as good as dead because they had rebelled against him. Rebellion against a human king was a capital crime; how much more serious it was for God's people to rebel against their heavenly king. • I wanted to redeem them: This Hebrew word means paying a fee to repatriate someone who has been enslaved. It is often associated with the exodus from Egypt. The Lord desired to do for the Israelites what he did when he brought their ancestors out of their slavery to pagan gods, but they ... told lies about him.

Hosea 7:14

They cut themselves: Self-mutilation was characteristic of Canaanite worship (see [1 Kgs 18:28](#)); it was prohibited in Israel ([Deut 14:1](#)).

Hosea 7:16

A crooked (literally *loose*) bow cannot propel its arrow to the target; it depicts Israel's futility apart from God (see [7:8](#), [11](#)).

Hosea 8:1

Sound the alarm: The ram's horn trumpet (shofar) called the people to worship ([Ps 98:6](#)); it was also (as here) the signal for battle ([2 Sam 20:1](#)). God was sending an enemy, the Assyrians, to execute his judgment on Israel. • revolted against my law: God's law (Hebrew torah) is much more than the sum of the individual laws in the Pentateuch. It represents the totality of God's instruction to his people through his words and his deeds. Loving fulfillment of the Torah was Israel's part of the covenant. They had broken God's commandments, and they had turned aside from their covenant relationship with the Lord.

Hosea 8:3

Jesus tells us that God alone is good ([Mark 10:18](#)). God is the source of every good thing, yet Israel rejected him.

Hosea 8:4

appointed kings without my consent: The Israelites quickly disposed of one king and appointed another if they thought it might save their nation (see [7:7](#)). They did all of this without consulting their true king, the Lord.

Hosea 8:5-6

this calf: When Jeroboam I (931-910 BC), the first king of the northern kingdom of Israel, ascended the throne, he established places of worship in the cities of Dan and Bethel so that the people would not travel to the Temple in Jerusalem, the capital of the southern kingdom. At each site, he erected a gold calf for the people to worship ([1 Kgs 12:26-30](#)).

Hosea 8:7

When Hosea proclaimed divine judgment, the punishment fit the crime (see study note on 4:10). Through their idolatry and political intrigue, the Israelites had planted the seeds of their own destruction (see [Gal 6:7](#)).

Hosea 8:9

Like a wild donkey: Hosea compared Israel's worship of the Canaanite fertility gods to an animal in heat that was desperate to mate (see [Jer 2:23-24](#)).

Hosea 8:10

I will now gather them together: Although God sometimes promises to gather his people for deliverance ([Zech 10:8-10](#)), here the Lord would gather them for judgment ([Joel 3:11](#)).

Hosea 8:11

Israel has built many altars: As Israel's idolatry increased, her religious activities increased in an attempt to take away sin; instead, these rites only increased her sin.

Hosea 8:13

I do not accept their sacrifices: See [6:6](#); [Isa 1:10-17](#); [Amos 5:21-24](#); [Mic 6:6-8](#). • They will return to Egypt, the place of slavery ([Deut 28:68](#)). God's dealings with Israel did not end with judgment. The divine purpose of judgment was to restore Israel to the status they had when they came out of Egypt, so that they could experience a new beginning (see [Hos 2:14-15](#)).

Hosea 8:14

Israel has forgotten its Maker: See [2:13](#). • God's judgment is often described as fire sent upon the royal palaces and fortresses (see [Amos 1:4, 7](#)).

Hosea 9:1

- *Do not rejoice*: This likely refers to the Feast of Tabernacles, when Israel celebrated the year's final harvest. God ordained this festival ([Deuteronomy 16:13-15](#)), but the Israelites turned it into a wild pagan celebration, acting like other nations.
- *you have played the harlot* (literally *you have loved a prostitute's pay*): The Israelites mistakenly believed their grain and wine were rewards for worshipping the Canaanite fertility god.

Hosea 9:2

As punishment for their prostitution, the Lord would so reduce the Israelites' harvests that they would go hungry (cp. [Hag 1:3-11](#)).

Hosea 9:3

God would exile the Israelites to Assyria in 722 BC. There, in an unclean land, they would eat ceremonially unclean food, further separating themselves from their covenant with the Lord.

Hosea 9:4

In exile, the Israelites could not offer legitimate sacrifices because any sacrifice in a foreign land was unclean and defiled.

Hosea 9:6

Even if some Israelites were to escape Assyrian exile by fleeing to Egypt, God's relentless judgment would reach them there.

Hosea 9:7

Apostate Israelites refused to believe God's words of judgment as delivered by the prophets and mockingly cried that the prophets were crazy.

Hosea 9:8

The watchman stood guard on the wall of the city to warn of any threat (e.g., [1 Sam 14:16](#)). In the same way, a prophet was God's watchman, stationed to warn Israel of her sin and of the judgment that sin would inevitably bring (see [Jer 6:17](#); [Ezek 3:17](#)). Despite his service to the people, all the prophet received was hostility.

Hosea 9:9

what they did in Gibeah long ago: See [Judg 19-21](#).

Hosea 9:10

when I first found you: Hosea, like Ezekiel ([Ezek 16](#)), speaks of the Lord's finding and adopting chaste, innocent Israel in the desert. But Israel soon deserted God for idols at Baal-peor ([Num 25:1-4](#)). Participation in idolatry had made the Israelites vile. This strong word can also be translated "detestable" ([Deut 29:17](#)) or "Abominable" ([Jer 7:30](#)). They inevitably resembled what they worshiped.

Hosea 9:11

Israel worshiped the baals to ensure that they would have many children, but God would punish

them by preventing birth, pregnancy, and even conception.

Hosea 9:13

for slaughter: Rather than gaining them more children, the Israelites' idolatry would backfire, resulting in their children's deaths.

Hosea 9:15

All their wickedness began at Gilgal: Gilgal was the base camp for Joshua's army ([Josh 5:10](#); [10:6](#), [43](#)) and the place where Saul was made king ([1 Sam 11:15](#)). Saul also disobeyed God and was rejected as king at Gilgal ([1 Sam 13:8-15](#); [15:10-23](#)). Israel's leaders, including its first king, had led the nation away from their true king, the Lord. • I will love them no more: Although a different Hebrew word is used here, the prophetic judgment reflects the name of Hosea's daughter ([Hos 1:6](#)).

Hosea 9:17

wanderers: God's judgment on the Israelites would cut them off from the land, leaving them with no home.

Hosea 10:1

Although Israel was God's luxuriant, fruitful vine (see [Isa 5:1-7](#); [Jer 2:21](#); [Ezek 17:6](#)), she falsely attributed her prosperity to the Canaanite fertility gods, rather than to the Lord, and she spent the riches God had given her to enhance her worship of idols. • sacred pillars: Stone pillars could be acceptable memorials ([Gen 35:20](#); [Josh 24:26-27](#)), but God prohibited the Israelites from using them in worship as the Canaanites did ([Exod 23:24](#); [Deut 16:22](#)).

Hosea 10:3

We have no king: Some interpreters see these words as an acknowledgement, after the destruction of Israel, that they had been punished and the monarchy had come to an end because they didn't fear the Lord. Others regard this as the Israelites' arrogant rejection of the Lord's kingship.

Hosea 10:4

The perversion of justice is like bitter, poisonous weeds ([Amos 6:12](#)).

Hosea 10:5-6

Israel's gold calf idol (see [8:5-6](#)) would become a prize of war for the invading Assyrians.

Hosea 10:8

The only response of Israelites who survived the coming catastrophe would be to implore the mountains and hills, "Bury us! . . . Fall on us!"

Hosea 10:9-10

The horrible events at Gibeah ([Judg 19-21](#)) set the pattern of sin for the people of the northern kingdom of Israel (see [Hos 9:9](#)). God's punishment was that they would be overwhelmingly defeated in war, just as in the time of the judges (see [Judg 2:10-15](#)).

Hosea 10:11

Because Israel was not faithful to the covenant, the Lord placed on her a heavy yoke—the divine correction required to bring her back to him.

Hosea 10:12

Using metaphors from agriculture, God set forth his requirements for his people and a promise of blessing if they did what he commanded (see [6:6](#); [8:7](#)). Even as Hosea announced God's judgment, he offered Israel the chance to repent and receive God's blessing.

Hosea 10:14

When Shalman destroyed Beth-arbel: This event is not mentioned elsewhere in the Bible or in other available sources, but it was evidently well known to Hosea's audience.

Hosea 11:1

my son: The Lord adopted Israel when he delivered him out of Egypt. This verse is quoted in reference to Jesus in [Matt 2:15](#) (see study note on Matt 4:1–11).

Hosea 11:1–11

God agonized over Israel's unfaithfulness. Despite all he had done, Israel had become a rebel. Justice required severe punishment, but the final sentence for Israel would be determined by God's tender compassion for his people, not by an abstract principle.

Hosea 11:2

In spite of God's love, Israel had become a rebellious child, offering sacrifices to ... Baal. The penalty for a rebellious son was death ([Deut 21:18–21](#)).

Hosea 11:3–4

God's nurture of the infant Israel was marked by kindness and love.

Hosea 11:5–7

Because the Israelites had refused to return to the Lord, they would return to Egypt and . . . serve Assyria. Their past bondage in Egypt was a symbol for their coming exile in Assyria.

Hosea 11:8

Though justice demanded Israel's death, the Lord recoiled at the thought of giving Israel up, of letting them go, of destroying his son. • Admah and Zeboiim were cities near Sodom and Gomorrah that God totally destroyed ([Deut 29:23](#)). • In Hebrew thought, the heart is the center of the intellect and the will.

Hosea 11:9

No: The Lord alone would determine Israel's fate. God repeated the words I will not three times, emphasizing his decision not to completely destroy his people. • The reason for the divine decision is, I am the Holy One living among you. God's holiness distinguishes him from every created thing (see "God's Absolute Holiness" Theme Note). An offended mortal might very well destroy a rebel out of pique and spite. The Holy One does not operate out of those motives.

Hosea 11:10–11

Israel's sin would not have the final word; God, in his holy love, would roar like a lion (see [Amos 1:2; 3:8](#)) to call his people home from exile.

Hosea 11:12–12.14

Israel had perpetrated lies and deceit since the time of Jacob.

Hosea 12:1

alliance with Assyria: In order to save his land, Hoshea became a vassal of King Shalmaneser of Assyria ([2 Kgs 17:3](#)). Hoshea soon rebelled against Shalmaneser by withholding tribute and turned to King So of Egypt for support ([2 Kgs 17:4](#)). • east wind: See study note on Job 38:24–27.

Hosea 12:3

Jacob struggled with his brother (literally *he supplanted his brother*): This verb (Hebrew 'aqab) forms the root of Jacob's name. Even before he was born, Jacob acted out the meaning of his name by supplanting his brother Esau ([Gen 25:26](#)). • As an adult, Jacob even fought with God (see [Gen 32:22–30](#)) and was renamed "Israel," meaning "God fights."

Hosea 12:4

at Bethel he met God: See [Gen 28:11–22](#).

Hosea 12:6

The Lord admonished Israel to live no longer as Jacob did, but to return to God and act with love and justice.

Hosea 12:7–8

During the reign of Jeroboam II (793–753 BC), Israelite merchants became fabulously wealthy, often by using deceitful business practices like dishonest scales (see [Amos 8:5–6](#)). • The Hebrew term translated merchants is *kena'an* (“Canaan”). Canaanite traders were notorious in the ancient world for their crafty dealings. The Israelites had imitated their pagan neighbors not only in religion but also in commerce.

Hosea 12:9

I will make you live in tents again: God’s judgment on the wealthy Israelite merchants was for them to return to the humble dwellings of the Exodus. There is also a word of hope here: God’s plan of salvation for Israel would begin anew in the wilderness (see [2:14–15](#)).

Hosea 12:11

Gilead and Gilgal were Israelite cities in which Baal was worshiped instead of the Lord (see [4:15](#); [6:8](#); [9:15](#)).

Hosea 12:13

by a prophet: Moses’ faithful obedience to God contrasts with Israel’s disobedience.

Hosea 13:1

At the height of its power, the tribe of Ephraim evoked terror among other Israelites (see [Isa 7:2](#)). • and thus sealed their destruction (literally *and he [Ephraim] died*): Because of their idolatry, they had cut themselves off from the Lord, the only true source of life.

Hosea 13:2

The Hebrew word translated idols is the same one used of the gold calf ([Exod 32:4, 8](#); see also [Hos 10:5–6](#); [Amos 5:5–6](#)). • kiss the calf idols: The Canaanite religious rituals included kissing images of Baal ([1 Kgs 19:18](#)).

Hosea 13:3

God’s judgment on idolatrous Ephraim was that they would disappear (cp. [6:4](#)). • Mist . . . dew . . . chaff and smoke signify impermanence.

Hosea 13:4–5

there is no other savior: The Lord had proved this to Israel during the Exodus and the wilderness wandering.

Hosea 13:6

you became proud and forgot me: They relied not on the Lord for security, but on their kings, armies, and economic prosperity (see [2:13](#)).

Hosea 13:7–8

God had executed judgment on Israel through the Assyrian army, his instrument of punishment. The description of God’s attack speaks of the Assyrians’ cruelty to those they conquered.

Hosea 13:9

me, your only helper: See [Pss 70:5](#); [115:9](#); [121:2](#); [124:8](#). Israel’s sin had turned their helper into their destroyer.

Hosea 13:10

where is your king? When Hoshea’s alliance with Egypt failed (see [12:1](#)), he tried to make peace with Assyria, but he was captured and imprisoned ([2 Kgs 17:4](#)). The Israelites had relied on their armies and kings to save them rather than on the Lord, and now there was no one to save them.

Hosea 13:11

Israel had crowned her kings without consulting the Lord, so now he would take them away in fury.

Hosea 13:12

God had carefully stored up the record of Israel's sin and guilt. He could not escape his punishment.

Hosea 13:13

Israel was like a child in the womb who resists being born (literally *an unwise son*). Incredibly, Israel would rather stay in the womb than receive life from the Lord.

Hosea 13:14

The term here translated the grave (Hebrew *Sheol*) refers to the realm of the dead (see [Job 3:11-19](#); see also study note on Job 7:9). The Lord is sovereign even over Sheol, and he could redeem Israel if he chose to. But he will not take pity on the Israelites, and he calls upon death to punish them.

Hosea 13:16

In 722 BC, Assyria captured Samaria, the capital of the northern kingdom ([2 Kgs 17:5-6](#)). Thousands died during the three-year siege, and thousands more were sent into exile. This was because they rebelled against their God. • The horrible practice of killing pregnant women is also mentioned in [Amos 1:13](#) and [2 Kgs 15:16](#).

Hosea 14:1-9

Destruction was not God's last word to his covenant people. Although judgment must come, God's healing, restoring grace is always more powerful than human sin.

Hosea 14:2-3

Hosea composed a model prayer of confession to help his people return to the Lord. God's prophets not only identified with God in his outrage over Israel's rebellion; they also identified with the people in their broken condition (see also [Dan 9:4-19](#)). • Forgive all our sins: The Israelites should throw themselves upon God's mercy and grace, freely acknowledging their many sins. • so that we may offer you our praises: Israel's inclination was to offer animal sacrifices for sin, but the Lord had made it clear that sacrifices were not the solution (see [Hos 6:6](#)). Israel should offer God genuine repentance.

Hosea 14:3

The Israelites must renounce their dependence upon idols, foreign alliances, and their own military strength. Although they were God's own children ([11:1](#)), they made themselves orphans through their rebellion. When they sincerely and completely repented, they could again find mercy.

Hosea 14:4

Then I will heal you: Healing by God is the only solution for the disease of sin. The Lord heals all our diseases, both physical and spiritual ([Ps 103:3](#)).

Hosea 14:5

like a refreshing dew: In the semi-desert climate of Israel, dew was an important source of life-giving moisture ([Gen 27:28](#); [Deut 33:28](#)). • it will send roots deep: When Israel lived in faithfulness to their covenant with the Lord, they would be solid and stable like the majestic cedars in Lebanon ([Ps 92:12](#)).

Hosea 14:5-7

Hosea describes the effect of God's healing love on repentant Israel. God promises to provide the fertility that Israel had sought from the baals.

Hosea 14:7

under my shade: A place of safety and relief ([Ps 91:1](#); [Isa 25:4](#)).

Hosea 14:8

Hosea exhorts Israel one final time to stay away from idols. Their life comes only from the Lord; he is an evergreen tree that always bears fruit.

Hosea 14:9

This final verse commends Hosea's words to wise and discerning believers of all generations.